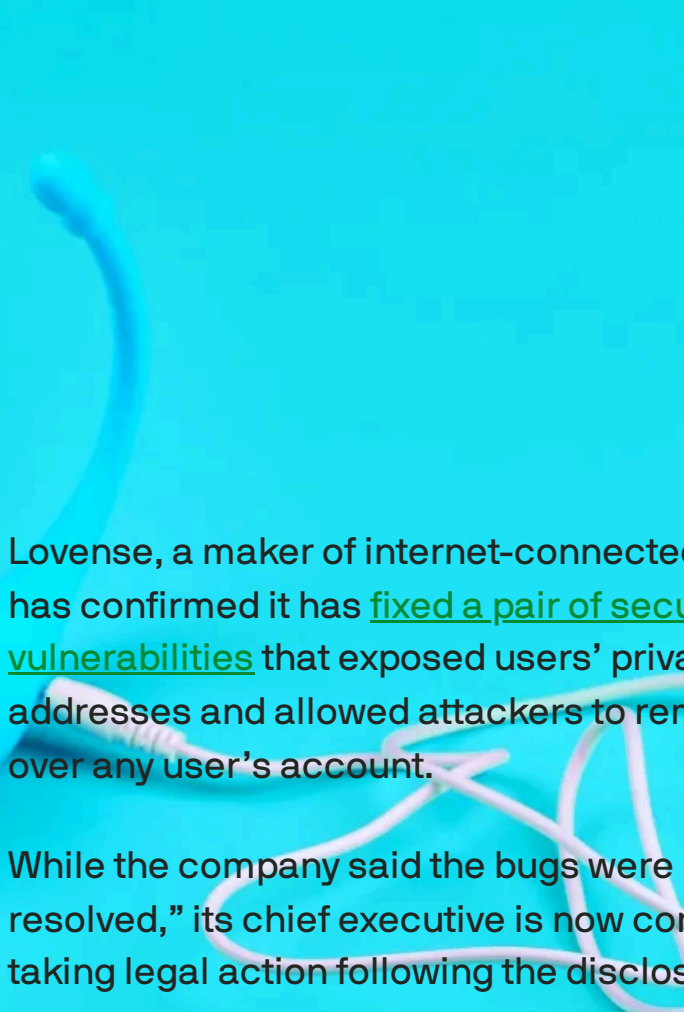


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SECURITY



**Sex toy maker Lovense
threatens legal action
after fixing security flaws
that exposed users' data**



Lovense, a maker of internet-connected sex toys, has confirmed it has [fixed a pair of security vulnerabilities](#) that exposed users' private email addresses and allowed attackers to remotely take over any user's account.

While the company said the bugs were “fully resolved,” its chief executive is now considering taking legal action following the disclosure.

In [a statement](#) shared with TechCrunch, Lovense CEO Dan Liu said the sex toy maker was “investigating the possibility of legal action” in response to ~~allegedly erroneous reports~~ about the bug. When asked by TechCrunch, the company did not respond to clarify whether it was referring to media reports or to a security researcher's disclosure.

Details of the bug emerged this week after a security researcher, who goes by the handle BobDaHacker, disclosed that they [reported the two security bugs](#) to the sex toy maker earlier this year. The researcher published their findings after Lovense claimed it would take 14 months to fully address the vulnerabilities rather than applying a “faster, one-month fix” that would have required alerting users to update their apps.

Lovense said in its statement, attributed to Liu, that the fixes put in place will require users to update

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their apps before they can resume using all of the app's features.

In the statement, Liu claimed that there is “no evidence suggesting that any user data, including email addresses or account information, has been compromised or misused.” It's not clear how Lovense came to this conclusion, given TechCrunch ([and other outlets](#)) verified the email disclosure bug by setting up a new account and asking the researcher to identify the associated email address.

TechCrunch asked Lovense what technical means, such as logs, the company has to determine if there was any compromise of users' data, but a spokesperson did not respond.

It's not unheard of for organizations to resort to legal demands and threats to try to block the disclosure of embarrassing security incidents, despite few rules or restrictions in the U.S. prohibiting such reporting.

Earlier this year, a U.S. independent journalist [rebuffed a legal threat](#) from a U.K. court injunction for accurately reporting a ransomware attack on U.K. private healthcare giant HCRG. In 2023, a county official in Hillsborough County, Florida, [threatened criminal charges against a security researcher](#) under the state's computer hacking laws for identifying and privately disclosing a security flaw in the county's court records system that exposed access to sensitive filings.

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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IMAGE CREDITS: TEAONHER (MODIFIED)

SECURITY

TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker

12:40 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have

supposedly dated, has exposed users’ personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they date. Tea is advertised as a women’s safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to “[Are we dating the same guy?](#)” Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea’s App Store description in its own listing.

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver’s licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver’s licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

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In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user’s email address, display name, and self-reported location.

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone’s data. The app’s maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app’s current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin’s own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and plaintext password belonging to the app’s creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app’s “admin” panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

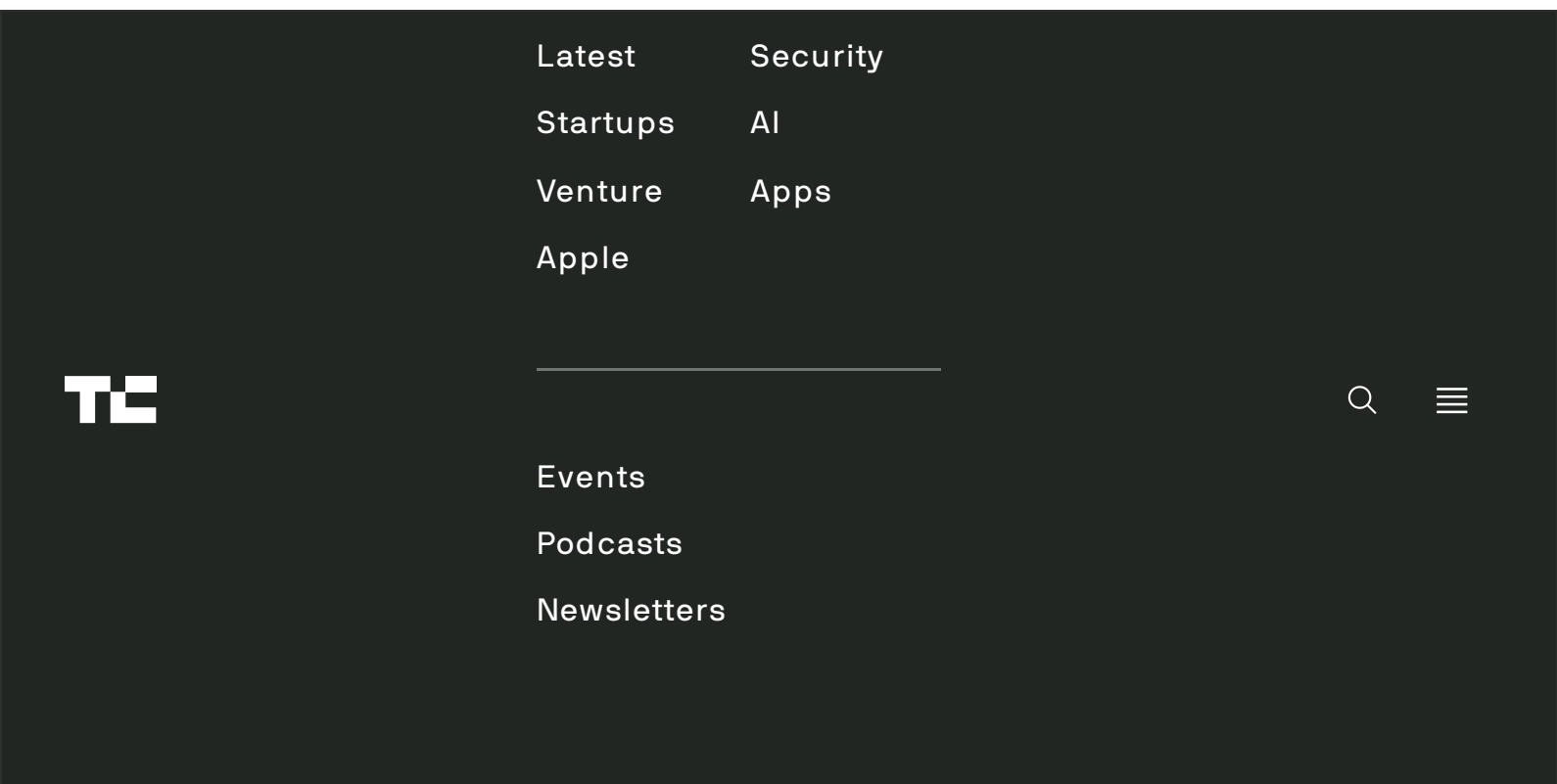
Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users

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can access a “guest” view of the app without signing in.

Immediately upon opening “guest” view, TechCrunch saw several images of the same naked woman, posted under different names in a form of spam. It is not clear if this woman consented to this photo being shared. Other posts share the photos and names of women, alongside comments calling them “easy,” or accusing them of spreading sexually transmitted infections.

Across all free apps, TeaOnHer is ranked No. 17, higher than apps like Instagram, Netflix, Uber, and Spotify. Tea is currently ranked No. 2.



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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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Google says hackers stole its customers’ data by breaching its Salesforce database

Zack Whittaker — 5:05 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: LEON NEAL / GETTY IMAGES

Google has confirmed that some customers’ information has been stolen in a recent breach of

one of its databases.

In [a blog post](#) late on Tuesday, Google Threat Intelligence Group said one of its Salesforce database systems, used to store contact information and related notes for small and medium-sized businesses, was breached by a hacking group popularly known as ShinyHunters, formally designated as UNC6040.

“The data retrieved by the threat actor was confined to basic and largely publicly available business information, such as business names and contact details,” the company said.

Google did not disclose how many customers are affected, and Google spokesperson Mark Karayan declined to comment beyond the company’s blog post. It’s not clear if the company has received any communication, such as a ransom demand.

ShinyHunters is known for targeting big companies and their cloud-based databases.

This is the latest in a series of breaches targeting Salesforce cloud systems, after recent thefts of [customer data from Cisco](#) and [airline giant Qantas](#), [retail giant Pandora](#), among others, as [reported by Bleeping Computer](#). According to Google’s blog post, the ShinyHunters group relies on voice phishing techniques to trick company employees into granting them access to their cloud-based Salesforce databases.

Google said the ShinyHunters group is likely preparing a data leak site, which some ransomware gangs use to publish stolen data to [extort their corporate victims](#) into paying a ransom. The group is said to have overlaps with other groups, [including The Com](#), a known collective of cybercriminals who use hacking, extortion, and

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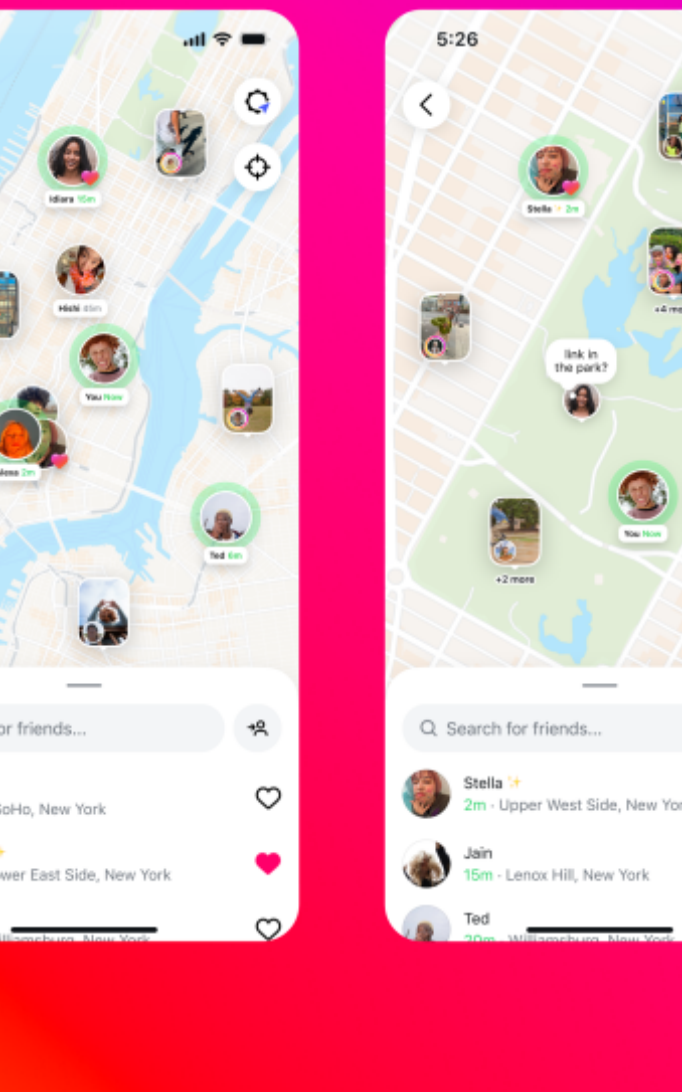


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

APPS

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

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Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user's location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn't provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It's worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple's Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.

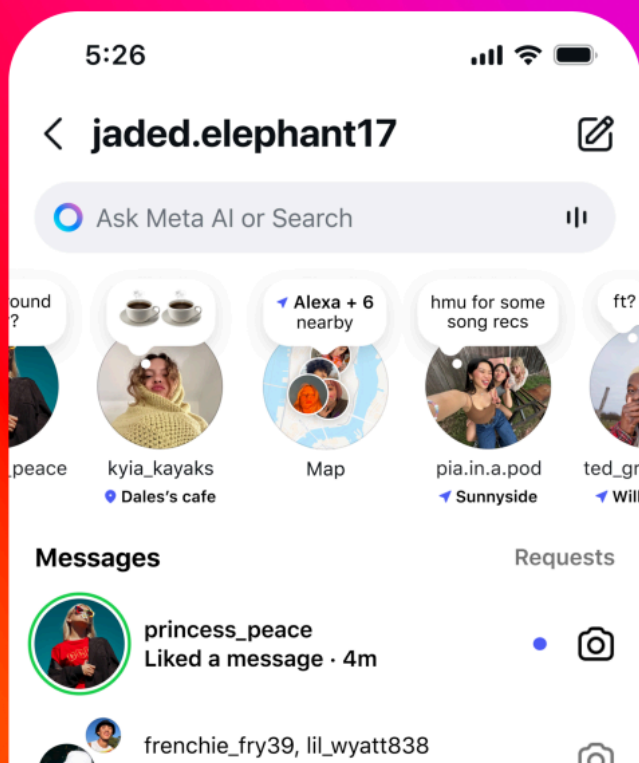


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

Instagram says the new map feature will make it easier for friends to coordinate and link up for hangouts. It also lets users explore location-based content that their friends and favorite creators have shared or engaged with. For example, if your friend attends a nearby music festival and posts a story while there, it will appear on the map. Similarly, if a

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creator posts a reel about a new restaurant in your city, you'll be able to discover it on Instagram Map.

Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or [“Notes,”](#) on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.

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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.

IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new "Reposts" feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok's book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular "retweet" function from Twitter (now X).

This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends' feeds and will also be displayed in a new "Reposts" tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

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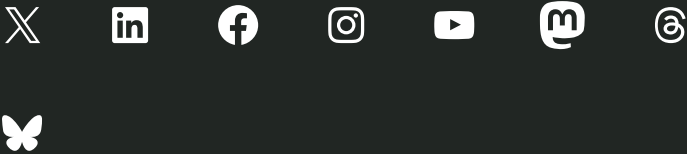
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Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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